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Early Adulthood: Understanding Social Development and Modern Challenges.

Definition and Social Development

- **Concept of Early Adulthood**

Early adulthood is a major stage in human life that usually starts at age 18 and lasts until about 40. For most people, this is the time when they are at their strongest and healthiest. However, it is not just about physical growth; it is a time of significant life changes. During these years, individuals transition from being teenagers and start making serious decisions about their future. According to Waite-Jones and Rodriguez (2025), early adulthood is a vital period where people build their own identity and learn how to take care of their long-term health and well-being. It is a time for exploring new opportunities and setting the foundation for the rest of one's life.

- **Social Development in Early Adulthood**.

Social development during this stage is about how a person learns to live as an independent adult in society. It involves changing how we relate to our family, friends, and the community. Instead of following what parent's guidance, young adults must exercise autonomous decision-making.

There are several parts to this development. First is "Independence", where a person learns to managing financial and emotional autonomy. Second is "Building Relationships"; young adults start moving beyond casual social circles toward deep, long-term emotional connections, instead of just having many casual friends. Third is "Career Growth", which involves entering the workforce and learning how to act professionally with bosses and coworkers. Finally, it involves "Social Responsibility", like becoming a parent or participating in community activities. Collaço et al. (2025) explain that successfully navigating these transitions is essential for a person's mental health and happiness.

- **The Importance of Intimate Relationship**

To understand why relationships are so important at this age, we can look at Erik Erikson's Psychosocial Theory. He focused on a stage called "Intimacy vs. Isolation", which happens during early adulthood.

- The Need for Intimacy

Erikson believed that after a person knows who they are, their next big task is to share their life with others. Intimacy means being able to have a close, honest, and loving relationship with a partner or a very close friend. This important because it gives people emotional support and makes them feel safe and loved.

- Intimacy vs. Isolation

If a young adult finds good relationships, they feel happy and connected. However, if they are afraid of getting hurt or cannot trust others, they might end up feeling lonely. Erikson called this "Isolation". Research by Arya et al. (2025) shows that having a good relationship is one of the main reasons why young adults feel satisfied with their lives. People who have strong social support are much better at dealing with stress than those who feel alone.

- **Social Challenges and Practical Solutions in Sri Lanka.**
- The Major Challenge: Economic Crisis and Youth Unemployment.

In Sri Lanka today, young adults face a very difficult situation due to the economic crisis and the lack of good jobs. According to Ranasinghe (2022), high youth unemployment and economic instability significantly hinder social integration, preventing young adults from reaching their full potential. This has completely changed how they grow socially and professionally. Many traditional jobs do not pay enough, which leads to new trends like migration and online work.

- **How these challenges affect development?**

1. Migration and brain drain:
   Because there are no good job opportunities, many people are leaving Sri Lanka to work in another countries Ranasinghe (2022). This often results in emotional distress as individuals lose their primary social support system stress because they lose their family support system during a very important time in their lives

2. Shift to Digital Spaces:

Due to the job crisis and low salaries, many youths are moving toward online platforms like “Forex trading”. Observational evidence suggests that many young adults experience similar challenges, as seen in various social contexts. He completed a degree in Hotel Management and worked in a leading hotel for five years. Despite his education and long experience, the salary was not enough to survive the rising cost of living. Because of this, he started trading on the side. Eventually, he earned enough to leave his hotel job and was even able to purchase his own vehicle. While this is an individual success, it creates a “labor vacuum” in essential local industries like tourism because skilled professionals are leaving their fields to work in digital spaces.

3. Delayed Independence: As mentioned by Caputo (2020), economic instability often leads to “parental co-residence”, where young adults continue to live with their parents much longer than they want to. In Sri Lanka, even those who earn well through online work often stay at home to save money. This can delay their transition into full social independence and slow down their ability to start their own families.

- **Practical Suggestions for Healthy Development.**

1. Salary Reforms and Job Security: The government and private sector must work together to increase wages, especially for skilled professionals like those in the hotel and tech industries. If people can earn a fair wage at home, they will not feel forced to migrate.

2. Mental Health Support: There should be more community-based counseling centers to help young adults deal with the stress of the economy. This will prevent them from falling into social isolation and help them maintain healthy relationship even during hard times.

3. Support for the Digital Economy: Since many youths are turning to trading and freelancing, the government should provide legal recognition and financial training for them manage their income better and contribute to the national economy.

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